



GOVERNANCE DOCUMENT

Gifts, Benefits and Hospitality Policy

International Society of Equity Analysts

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This document forms part of the official governance framework of the International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) and should be read together with the related documents listed above.

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1. Purpose

The International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) is committed to maintaining the highest standards of integrity, transparency and professionalism in its dealings with Members, sponsors, partners, research providers, service providers, conference participants and other stakeholders.

This Gifts, Benefits and Hospitality Policy ("Policy") establishes the framework governing the offering, giving, soliciting and acceptance of gifts, benefits and hospitality by persons connected with ISEA.

ISEA recognises that gifts, benefits and hospitality, where improperly offered, given, solicited or accepted, may compromise, or may be perceived to compromise, independence, objectivity and professional judgement, and may give rise to actual, potential or perceived conflicts of interest.

This Policy is intended to protect the integrity of ISEA's governance, professional standards, membership processes and reputation, and to support the ethical principles established under ISEA's Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct ("Code").

This Policy operates alongside the Code, the Conflict of Interest Policy and other applicable ISEA policies, regulations and governance requirements.

2. Scope and Application

This Policy applies to:

- the Governing Council members;
- the Secretary-General and officers of the Executive Secretariat;
- committee members;
- ISEA Members (Student Members, Associate Members, Members and Fellows);
- holders of ISEA professional certifications and designations;
- volunteers and representatives acting on behalf of ISEA; and
- contractors, service providers and other persons engaged by ISEA, where applicable, (each a "Relevant Person").

This Policy also applies to gifts, benefits and hospitality offered by, or received from, sponsors, partners, research providers, companies, conference exhibitors, membership applicants and other external stakeholders in connection with ISEA activities.

By becoming a Member of ISEA, obtaining an ISEA certification or designation, holding an ISEA governance or representative position, or participating in an ISEA professional program or activity, an individual acknowledges the obligations applicable to them under this Policy.

3. Definitions

For the purposes of this Policy:

- "Gift" means any item, product or other thing of value given or received without something of reasonably comparable value being given in exchange, including physical items, vouchers, tickets, discounts or other items of value.
- "Benefit" means any advantage, favour, service or preferential treatment provided to, or by, a person in connection with their role or association with ISEA.
- "Hospitality" means the provision of meals, refreshments, entertainment, travel, accommodation or similar courtesies extended in a business or professional context.
- "Nominal Value" means a value that is modest by ordinary business and cultural standards, and that is unlikely to influence, or be perceived to influence, professional judgement or decision-making, as further described in guidance issued by the Ethics and Professional Standards Committee from time to time.

- "Public Official" means any officer, employee or representative of a government, regulatory authority, stock exchange, central bank, or other public or statutory body.

4. Guiding Principles

ISEA expects Relevant Persons to observe the following principles when offering, giving, soliciting or accepting gifts, benefits or hospitality.

4.1 Integrity and Professional Judgement

Gifts, benefits and hospitality shall never be offered, given, solicited or accepted in a manner that compromises, or could reasonably be perceived to compromise, independence, objectivity or professional judgement.

4.2 Proportionality and Reasonableness

Any gift, benefit or hospitality must be reasonable and proportionate in value and frequency, having regard to the nature of the relationship, the occasion and ordinary business and cultural practice.

4.3 Transparency and Disclosure

Relevant Persons shall be open and transparent about gifts, benefits and hospitality offered, given, solicited or received, and shall disclose these in accordance with Section 9 where required.

4.4 No Improper Influence

Gifts, benefits and hospitality shall never be offered, given, solicited or accepted with the intention, or reasonably perceived intention, of improperly influencing a decision, research outcome, investment recommendation, membership or certification determination, disciplinary process or procurement decision.

4.5 Cultural Sensitivity

ISEA operates across jurisdictions in which cultural practices concerning gift-giving and hospitality may vary. Relevant Persons shall exercise sound judgement, and where local custom might otherwise exceed the standards set out in this Policy, shall seek guidance from the Ethics and Professional Standards Committee.

5. Permitted Gifts, Benefits and Hospitality

Subject to the principles in Section 4 and the disclosure requirements in Section 9, the following are ordinarily permissible:

- gifts of Nominal Value, including branded promotional items and customary seasonal greetings items;
- reasonable working meals and refreshments provided in connection with legitimate ISEA business, meetings or conferences;
- attendance at conferences, seminars, training programs or industry events that is reasonably connected to professional development or ISEA's activities;
- reciprocal hospitality of a modest and proportionate nature extended in the ordinary course of professional relationships with sponsors, partners, research providers and other stakeholders; and
- customary courtesies exchanged between professional counterparts that are consistent with the principles in Section 4.

6. Prohibited Gifts, Benefits and Hospitality

The following shall never be offered, given, solicited or accepted:

- cash or cash equivalents, in accordance with Section 7;

- gifts, benefits or hospitality that are lavish, excessive or disproportionate to the occasion or relationship;
- gifts, benefits or hospitality offered, given, solicited or accepted with an expectation, express or implied, of influencing any decision, research outcome, investment recommendation, membership or certification determination, disciplinary process or procurement decision;
- gifts, benefits or hospitality offered, given, solicited or accepted secretly, or otherwise than through open and transparent channels;
- gifts, benefits or hospitality that would breach applicable anti-bribery, anti-corruption or other laws, including those concerning Public Officials; and
- repeated or frequent gifts, benefits or hospitality from the same source which, whether individually or cumulatively, exceed the standards set out in this Policy.

7. Cash and Cash Equivalents

Cash, and instruments readily convertible into cash (including gift cards, vouchers and similar instruments), shall never be offered, given, solicited or accepted by a Relevant Person in connection with their role or association with ISEA, regardless of value.

This Section does not prevent the lawful reimbursement of reasonable, properly documented business expenses in accordance with ISEA's applicable policies and procedures.

8. Gifts, Benefits and Hospitality Involving Sponsors, Partners, Research Providers and Conference Participants

ISEA recognises that its Members, sponsors, partners, research providers, companies and conference participants may have commercial relationships with ISEA, and that these relationships give rise to particular sensitivities under this Policy.

- commercial arrangements with sponsors and partners shall be governed by separate written agreements approved in accordance with ISEA's governance requirements, and shall not be used as a means of circumventing this Policy;
- gifts, benefits or hospitality offered by a sponsor, partner, research provider or company to a Governing Council member, committee member, officer, employee or Member acting in an official ISEA capacity shall be disclosed in accordance with Section 9, irrespective of value, where offered in connection with that capacity;
- speaking arrangements, honoraria and similar benefits offered in connection with ISEA conferences or events shall be assessed in accordance with this Policy and the Conflict of Interest Policy;
- gifts, benefits or hospitality offered by a research provider, or by a company that is the subject of equity research or analysis, shall be subject to heightened scrutiny, having regard to the importance of research independence and objectivity under the Code; and
- sponsorship, exhibition or advertising arrangements at ISEA conferences or events shall not entitle a sponsor, partner or exhibitor to any influence over ISEA's membership, certification, research, disciplinary or governance decisions.

9. Disclosure and Approval Requirements

A Relevant Person shall disclose to the Secretary-General or the Ethics and Professional Standards Committee, within a reasonable time, any gift, benefit or hospitality that:

- exceeds Nominal Value;
- is offered or received on a recurring basis from the same source;
- involves travel or overnight accommodation; or
- otherwise gives rise to an actual, potential or perceived conflict of interest.

Where practicable, prior approval should be obtained before accepting hospitality involving travel or accommodation, or any gift, benefit or hospitality of uncertain permissibility under this Policy.

Where a Relevant Person is offered a gift, benefit or hospitality that would not be permitted under this Policy, they shall politely decline it or, where it has already been received, arrange for its return, donation to charity, or surrender to ISEA, and shall document the circumstances in accordance with Section 10.

A Relevant Person who is uncertain whether a gift, benefit or hospitality is permitted under this Policy should seek guidance from the Ethics and Professional Standards Committee before offering, giving, soliciting or accepting it.

10. Gifts, Benefits and Hospitality Register

ISEA shall maintain a register of disclosed gifts, benefits and hospitality, administered by the Executive Secretariat.

The register shall ordinarily record:

- the date and nature of the gift, benefit or hospitality;
- the parties involved;
- a description and estimated value;
- whether the gift, benefit or hospitality was accepted, declined, returned or donated; and
- any approval given and by whom.

The register shall be reviewed periodically by the Ethics and Professional Standards Committee, and shall be made available to the Governing Council upon request.

11. Roles and Responsibilities

The Governing Council is responsible for approving this Policy and any supporting guidance, including thresholds for Nominal Value, and for overseeing ISEA's compliance with this Policy.

The Secretary-General and the Executive Secretariat are responsible for administering the register described in Section 10, providing guidance to Relevant Persons, and referring matters of concern to the Ethics and Professional Standards Committee.

The Ethics and Professional Standards Committee is responsible for monitoring compliance with this Policy, reviewing disclosures, providing guidance on its interpretation and application, and recommending amendments to the Governing Council.

Relevant Persons are responsible for understanding and complying with this Policy, exercising sound judgement, making required disclosures, and seeking guidance where uncertain.

12. Breaches of this Policy

A breach of this Policy may constitute misconduct under the Code and may be dealt with in accordance with the Disciplinary Policy.

Concerns regarding a possible breach of this Policy may be raised in accordance with the Complaints Policy or, where appropriate, the Whistleblower Policy.

Depending on the nature and seriousness of a breach, consequences may include:

- guidance, counselling or a formal warning;
- requirement to return, donate or surrender a gift, benefit or hospitality;
- suspension or termination of membership, certification or designation;
- restrictions on participation in ISEA governance, committee or professional activities; or
- referral to a relevant regulatory, professional or other appropriate body.

13. Confidentiality and Privacy

Information disclosed under this Policy, and information recorded in the register described in Section 10, shall be handled with appropriate confidentiality and in accordance with ISEA's Privacy Policy and other applicable legal requirements.

Information may be disclosed where required by law, necessary for the proper conduct of an investigation or disciplinary process, necessary to protect the integrity of ISEA or its professional standards, required for legitimate regulatory or professional cooperation, or otherwise authorised by the Governing Council or an authorised ISEA body.

14. Review and Continuous Improvement

ISEA shall periodically review this Policy to ensure that it remains appropriate having regard to:

- developments in anti-bribery, anti-corruption and related laws and regulations;
- international professional practices concerning gifts, benefits and hospitality;
- the evolving nature of ISEA's commercial and sponsorship relationships;
- emerging risks identified through the register or disclosures made under this Policy; and
- feedback from Members, sponsors, partners and other stakeholders.

The Ethics and Professional Standards Committee shall recommend amendments where appropriate, subject to approval by the Governing Council.

15. Effective Date

This Policy takes effect on the date approved by the Governing Council.